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To the Editors of the Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Re: Direct Submission of the Research Report “Whether richer countries are happier depends on the survey” (Social Sciences, Economic Sciences)

Dear Editors,

I submit for your consideration the enclosed Research Report. It addresses a question of broad scientific and policy interest: do richer countries have higher well-being, and how far does national income predict it? The positive cross-country relation between log GDP per capita and average life evaluations, documented with the Gallup World Poll, is one of the most cited facts of well-being research and underpins rankings of the happiest countries as well as the view that growth delivers well-being.

The paper shows that this relation depends on the survey. In the World Values Survey (112 countries, 1981–2023), log GDP per capita explains on average 14% of the cross-country variance of eight well-being indicators, less than a country's broad world region (33%), which also predicts better out of sample. In the Gallup World Poll (168 countries), by contrast, income predicts life evaluations as well as region (61% vs. 48%). Because the two surveys differ both in their question (Cantril ladder vs. life satisfaction) and in their samples, I ran a pre-registered randomized experiment in an online survey of 11,000 respondents in ten countries, which varies the question wording and scale within the same sample. Asked to the same respondents, the ladder is better predicted by GDP than life satisfaction (R^2 of 0.61 vs. 0.28 across countries), which accounts for about half (56%, 95% CI 22–82%) of the Gallup–WVS difference in predictive capacity in these countries.

To my knowledge, this is the first experimental separation of question and sample effects in the cross-country relation between income and well-being. The results matter beyond economics: for psychologists and survey methodologists, who rely on these surveys to compare countries; for the World Happiness Report and statistical offices, whose rankings depend on the choice of survey and question; and for policymakers considering well-being as an objective of public policy. I believe this combination of a broad question, global data, and a randomized design suits the readership of PNAS.

Thank you for considering this submission.

Sincerely,

Adrien Fabre

